

Attenuated Families: The Role of the Kangany in the Exploitation of Family Relationships on Rubber Plantations in British Malaya

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*"The Bay of Bengal's circuits of migration both responded to and fueled change on a global scale. Malaya's rubber—tapped by Tamil migrant workers—fed the American automobile industry. Malaya became the most economically valuable tropical colony in the whole of the British Empire."*¹

- Sunil Amrith, *Crossing the Bay of Bengal*

Introduction

The rise of the automotive industry in the early twentieth century created a demand for rubber that could not be met by the Amazon. In 1913 Asian rubber plantations surpassed Amazonian production for the first time, and by the next year accounted for over half of all global natural rubber production. This was not so much due to the decline of Amazonian rubber but to an explosion of production on Southeast Asian plantations that would soon make peak Amazonian production look like little more than a rounding error. In 1912, the Amazon reached its peak production of 41,619 long tons, while Southeast Asia produced a little over 33 thousand. Just over 20 years later, in 1934, Amazonian production had fallen to

¹ Sunil S. Amrith, *Crossing the Bay of Bengal: The Furies of Nature and the Fortunes of Migrants* (Harvard University Press, 2013), 2.

less than 9,000 tons while Southeast Asia produced over a million: more than 98% of global production that year.² How did a sparsely populated region thousands of miles from the native home of *Hevea Brasiliensis* come to so thoroughly dominate its cultivation? This chapter will explore the rise of South Asian rubber in plantations of British Malaya, which accounted for between 40 and 50 percent of global production in the 1920s and 1930s.

The key to the rise of Asian rubber, and especially that in Malaya, was its plantation system. South Asia imported rubber plants that had been carefully cultivated in botanical gardens, and that were free of the South American Leaf Blight. This, combined with a favorable climate, an experienced class of planters and the consolidation of large plantations created the conditions for the rapid expansion of rubber cultivation, but the dominant factor was a massive system of exploitation of immigrant workers. Between 1840 and 1940, approximately 4 million people, mostly Tamils looking for work on rubber plantations, traveled from India to Malaya.³ Initially these workers were indentured - unfree for the length of their contract - but due to international pressure, indenture for Indian workers in Malaya was abolished in 1910. These workers, without whom the rapid expansion of rubber production would not have been possible, suddenly found themselves in the middle of a global struggle over the rights of workers and the status of free labor. Indian nationalists and international trade unionists insisted on legal rights of free labor, and so planters and colonial

2 P. W. Barker and E. G. Holt, "Rubber Statistics 1900-1937: Production, Absorption, Stocks and Prices," Trade Promotion Series (Washington: U. S. Department of Commerce, 1938).

3 Amrith, *Crossing the Bay of Bengal*, 104.

authorities were forced to try and resolve the contradiction between free labor and their desire to compel migrants to work under brutal, but profitable, conditions.

This contradiction was resolved, for a time, through the exploitation of family and community bonds via what was called the *kangany* system. This article will explore how family connections among workers, and between workers and overseers, were used to create a compliant workforce, while maintaining the legal fiction of free labor. I draw on colonial reports of the administrators of British Malaya, as well as the opinions of anti-indenture activists expressed in newspapers and trade union publications to demonstrate how the category of the free wage laborer was transformed in the context of South Asian rubber plantations by the exploitation of family relations, and how this propped up the global rubber industry.

The Arrival of Rubber in British Malaya

Rubber is a naturally occurring compound that can be found in thousands of plants around the globe, such as the common dandelion.⁴ Very few of these plants, however, produce rubber in commercially viable quantities or forms. The vast majority of naturally produced rubber is collected from the *Hevea Brasiliensis* plant, which grows natively in the Amazon. As early as the 1870s, seeds of the rubber plant were smuggled out of South America to Great Britain where they were studied at the Kew Gardens.⁵ The imperial countries of the West

⁴ John Tully, *The Devils Milk* (NYU Press, 2011), 21.

⁵ Tully, *The Devils Milk*, 185.

knew that wild-collected rubber from South America and Africa would not be able to meet industry's rising demand, and so they began to experiment with rubber plantations in other parts of the world - most prominently Malaya. In the course of the last decades of the nineteenth century and the first half of the twentieth, Malaya would be transformed from a predominantly peasant society into a highly specialized producer of plantation rubber, its residents dependent on imports from Japan, the UK and the USA for the basic everyday goods necessary for survival.

In the 1926 *Handbook to British Malaya*, prepared by the colonial apparatus of the Malayan Civil Service, the contention is made that "[t]rade, and not imperialistic aspiration, was the motive which brought the British to Malaya; the Spaniards and the Portuguese were the missionaries and conquerors." Although the trading posts and factories were to be transformed into forts, "[t]he consideration with which the natives were treated when our trade depended on their goodwill was continued as a matter of principle when the trading station became a colony."⁶ This description would surely come as a surprise to the predominantly Indian laborers on Malayan rubber estates whose exploitation at the hands of the British attracted the ire of groups ranging from local social activists to nationalists and reformers in India to communists in Britain itself. It does, however, indicate a desire on the part of the British colonizers to present at least the image of a free and equal partnership between themselves and the peoples they colonized in Malaya.

6 "Handbook to British Malaya" (London: Malay States Information Agency, 1926), 40.

The first British interests in Malaya were the Straits Settlements, most famously Singapore, but also Penang, Malacca and Dinding. These were primarily port cities, but they included some rural holdings that would become important agricultural producers. Throughout the British occupation of Malaya, the Straits Settlements served as the primary points of dis/embarkation for laborers coming to find work, or leaving for home at the end of their contracts. They were governed as part of British India until 1867 when they were constituted as a separate colony. At the end of the nineteenth century, the four Federated Malay States, Perak, Selangor, Negri Sembilan and Pahang, came under the administration of the British, and over the next few years, the Unfederated Malay States of Johor, Kedah, Kelantan, Perlis, and Terengganu also accepted British 'advisors'.

During this period of consolidation, the primary economic activity was tin mining, largely run on Chinese labor and backed by Chinese capital. Historian Jomo K. S. notes that tin production just from the state of Perak "rose from 650 tons in 1874 to 18,810 tons in 1893, while the other States produced 18,930 tons."⁷ This precipitous increase in production, driven by the development of British tin-plating, presented a problem for the largely peasant population of Malaya: "As there was no Malay proletariat who could be set to work on the mines, the existing Malay rulers agreed to arrangements from which they obtained large commissions from Chinese miners."⁸ By 1900, the Chinese population of the Federated Malay

⁷ Jomo Kwame Sundaram, *A Question of Class: Capital, the State, and Uneven Development in Malaya* (Singapore: Oxford University Press, 1986), 159.

⁸ Jomo Kwame Sundaram, *A Question of Class*, 157.

States was about 300,000, about 80% of which was employed in tin mines. This pattern of importing foreign workers to fulfill a labor demand that the indigenous population would not or could not meet would continue with the subsequent rise of Malayan agriculture.

Despite the dominance of tin, British authorities tried to encourage agricultural production. J Norman Parmer quotes the Secretary of State for the Colonies as writing in 1895 that the development of Malayan agriculture was the "point of greatest importance" if the Malay States were to remain profitable "when their mineral resources in the course of years show signs of depletion."⁹ Parmer notes that miners "felt strongly that the government was being biased and ungrateful. They correctly pointed out that the planters were being subsidized with the revenues which the mines produced."¹⁰ The most important crop throughout most of the nineteenth century was sugar which was planted in estates that were, like the tin mines, mostly owned by Chinese capital. According to Parmer, the British were at first reluctant to invest capital in Malayan plantations until "a leaf disease and bad times"¹¹ ruined coffee crops in Ceylon, forcing planters to look elsewhere to grow the crop. Coffee moved to Malay in the 1880s, and "[g]ood coffee prices in 1894-1895 furnished an impetus to the extension of coffee planting."¹² By the 1896, there were 47,000 acres in over 70 coffee plantations backed by European capital in Malaya, rivaling the economic output of the

9 Joseph Chamberlain quoted in J. Norman Parmer, *Colonial Labor Policy and Administration: A History of Labor in the Rubber Plantation Industry in Malaya*, Monographs of the Association for Asian Studies, IX (Locust Valley, NY: J. J. Augustin Incorporated Publisher, 1960), 6.

10 Parmer, *Colonial Labor Policy*, 6.

11 Parmer, *Colonial Labor Policy*, 7.

12 Parmer, *Colonial Labor Policy*, 7.

Chinese sugar estates. Almost immediately, however, the coffee price fell, and planters began to look again for alternative crops to maintain the profitability of their plantations. The most profitable of these was to be rubber.

Small rubber plantations had been established by the British in Assam in 1873, and a few years later in Ceylon, Indonesia and Singapore.¹³ For many years it remained a marginal crop in Malaya, mostly grown in state research gardens. It wasn't until the commodity price fall in the 1890s that Malayan planters began to plant it in earnest. Rising prices driven by the automotive industry's increasing demand for rubber as well as governmental incentives encouraged planters to convert more and more of their plantation acreage to rubber. The labor force on rubber estates grew to over 100,000 workers by 1910, a need that could be met neither by Chinese immigrants who were mostly employed in the still-productive tin mines, nor by the indigenous Malayan population. The next section will focus on the consolidation of smaller holdings into large rubber plantations, and the recruitment of Indian labor to work them.

The Recruitment of Foreign Workers to Malayan Estates

Prior to the rubber boom of 1910, the majority of the small amount of rubber produced in Malaya was grown by planters who owned their own farms. They had begun planting rubber alongside other crops in the 1890s to ward against falling coffee prices, but

¹³ Tully, *The Devils Milk*, 188.

soon began to convert most of their acreage to rubber. The boom of 1910 saw an influx of foreign capital, and many local planters began to sell their farms to European planters. Periodic slumps in the 1920s and 1930s squeezed the remaining small producers and furthered the consolidation of large rubber estates in the hands of European owners. By 1940, 2.1 million acres of rubber had been planted in estates ranging from 100 acres to over 10,000. Of this 2.1 million acres, 75% was owned by European capital, and a 20% by Chinese and Indian planters. In addition to this, a further 1.3 million acres of rubber was planted on small and medium sized farms of less than 100 acres each.¹⁴

The labor requirement to cultivate this crop was massive, though the plantation labor force fluctuated wildly. From 58,073 laborers in 1907, the employment on large estates rose to the twentieth century high of 332,300 in 1946. In the interim there were local peaks of 237,128 and 258,780 in 1919 and 1929 respectively, each of which was followed by a dramatic crash in which the labor pool contracted by a third to a half (down to 156,341 in 1921 and 123,924 in 1933).¹⁵ The growth and contraction of plantation labor was facilitated by large scale migration from other regions of Asia. Even before rubber cultivation, the labor demand on Malayan plantations was too great to be satisfied by the local Malayan population. Although migrants and slaves had been traveling to Malaya for centuries - Sunil Amrith states that the Bay of Bengal was a "maritime highway between India and China"¹⁶ - the demands of rubber

¹⁴ Parmer, *Colonial Labor Policy*, 8-9.

¹⁵ From a table compiled in Jomo Kwame Sundaram, *A Question of Class*, 181.

¹⁶ Amrith, *Crossing the Bay of Bengal*, 1.

production transformed the patterns of human mobility across the bay. As labor requirements and migration increased, largely comprising Tamil workers from Madras, so too did the administrative apparatus that governed migration. Over the course of the early twentieth century, the governments of India and Malaya, Malayan small-holders and European planters all formed associations and committees to try to direct the flow of workers to their own benefit. Through their negotiations, a complex set of labor and citizenship categories were developed. Amrith says that the increased governance of Tamil migration "linked the two coasts of the Bay of Bengal more closely together, and at the same time introduced new distinctions between different kinds of migration - free and unfree; 'assisted' and 'unassisted'; Chinese and Tamil - and between migrants and indigenes in Malaya."¹⁷

In the 1890s, prior to the large scale cultivation of rubber, already proprietary planters and estate managers were forming committees to address the labor shortage in Malaya. These committees would merge into the Planters Association of Malaya or PAM in 1907, and their primary interest was to petition the government to develop a migration apparatus that would secure a stable pool of migrant labor. Parmer notes that in many cases the planters were competing for labor with the government itself: "When European employers experienced difficulty in obtaining labor, they usually turned to the government asking that it assume some responsibility for the labor supply. Employers' demands were given added impetus by the tendency of plantation laborers to seek employment with the government which sometimes

17 Sunil S. Amrith, "Indians Overseas? Governing Tamil Migration to Malaya 1870-1941," *Past & Present* 208, no. 1 (August 2010), 232.

offered better wages."¹⁸ The government was slow to respond to employer demands, but due to pressure from PAM and other groups it slowly began to take measures to control the inflow of labor.

During the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries labor migration from India to Malaya, there were several mechanisms by which Indians migrated. There has always been some amount of unassisted free labor migration: workers who pay for their own journey and are in theory free to enter contracts with any employer. However, in the early decades of British rule, most workers who came to Malaya were indentured. Their transit was paid for by their future employers, the cost of which was then docked from their pay. In the late nineteenth century, the conditions of indentured labor were quite poor, and a Labor Commission was established in 1890 to conduct an inquiry into high mortality rates among indentured Indian laborers. The Commission recommended that the government take on responsibility for overseeing labor recruitment and for improving labor conditions.

The government of Malaya was reluctant to assume total responsibility for procuring labor on behalf of the planters, but being itself a major employer of Indian immigrant labor it saw the need for a steady and regulated inflow of migrant workers. In 1907 the Malayan government established the Indian Immigration Committee and the Tamil Immigration Fund to supervise the recruitment of workers from south India, as well as to pay for any associated costs.¹⁹ The fund was started with initial loans from the government, but thereafter drew its

¹⁸ Parmer, *Colonial Labor Policy*, 18.

¹⁹ Parmer, *Colonial Labor Policy*, 39.

money from assessments on any employers of Indian labor. As the government was a major employer of Indian labor it paid into the fund at the same rate as planters. The primary purpose of the Committee and its fund was to secure Indian labor at a fixed low cost and to discourage planters from poaching others' workers through high wages. The Indian Immigration Committee operated from its conception in 1907 until 1938 when India would outlaw all forms of assisted labor migration to Malaya.²⁰

At the same time that the Tamil Immigration Fund was established in Malaya, an anti-indenture movement was growing in India among various interests. The opposition to indenture came from two different sectors of Indian society, and they opposed indenture on rather different grounds. The local planters and ryots in Madras argued that the practice of indentured labor migration had a detrimental affect on the local labor market. They claimed that landless laborers were systematically dodging debts to their landlords by moving abroad, and they complained that returned coolies were in such ill health that they were no longer suited to agricultural labor. They appealed to the government of Madras to regulate indentured migration, but this was met with indifference. Although officials confirmed that many emigrants were leaving behind debts, they blamed the ryots for unfair labor practices which drove the workers to leave, suggesting that "that the Government could not do anything to protect the ryot until he realised that if he wanted to keep his labourers he must

²⁰ Parmer, *Colonial Labor Policy*, 57.

pay them better."²¹ The Raj, caring little for the profits of local Tamil planters, claimed that the system of emigration was for the workers own good, a 'free' labor market providing workers with the opportunity to move to wherever labor conditions suited them.

The planters were joined in denouncing emigration by Indian nationalists, although their complaints against indenture had less to do with promoting a domestic labor market, and more to do with bolstering a nascent republicanism that was concerned with the treatment of Indian citizens abroad. M.M. Mani notes that partisans of Indian independence, such as Gopalakrishna Gokhale, Mahatma Ghandi, and C.F. Andrews "wrote in the press and spoke on public platforms requesting the Government to abolish the system of Indentured labour emigration."²² Prominent among the newspapers carrying nationalist opinions were *The Hindu*, published in English in Tamil Nadu, and *New India*, a daily published by home rule advocate Annie Besant. The arguments made in these pages were often moral, emphasizing the evils of indenture as a national injury. Mani writes of *New India*, that "the paper inferred that the self respect of India was hurt by that 'refined and civilized form of slavery'. Commenting on emigration Mahatma Ghandi said that emigration did not do any good to the country from which people emigrated. The returned emigrants were morally corrupt."²³ A major aim of the nationalist propaganda was to counter the Raj's contention

21 M. M. Mani, "Abolition of Indentured Labour Emigration to the British and French Colonies: Role of the People, the Press, and the Planters of Tamilnadu," *Proceedings of the Indian History Conference 1957* (1996), 698.

22 Mani, "Abolition of Indentured Labour Emigration," 696.

23 Mani, "Abolition of Indentured Labour Emigration," 704.

that it maintained the system of indentured emigration to improve the lots of workers, and to demonstrate that under British rule, Indians were being systematically mistreated.

Ultimately, the Raj gave in to the combined pressure of the nationalists and the ryots. In 1910 indentured labor contracts were banned for migrants traveling to Malaya, although in-place contracts were allowed to run their course. In 1917, labor recruiting was temporarily paused due to the War, and a few years later the 1922 Emigration Act banned all indentured emigration.

The 1910 abolition of indentured labor to Malaya only applied to Indian labor, and Chinese and Javanese workers were still brought in on indenture contracts. However, most of the workers on rubber plantations were Tamils, and so the Tamil Immigration Fund had to find alternate ways of ensuring the continued influx of ready workers. They had two important considerations: They had to counter widespread reporting in India of the deplorable working conditions on Malayan plantations, and they had to find some way of compelling workers to stay on their plantations while still upholding the image of 'free labor'. Planters in Malaya were compelled to improve the living and working conditions on their estates - but only up to a point. In the legislation passed by the Malayan government, the primary reason given for the concern with labor conditions was not the well-being of the worker, but the detrimental effect that poor conditions had on recruitment.

Along with the difficulties of attracting labor, planters in Malaya found domestic reasons to pressure the Malayan government to regulate the supply of labor. This pressure

came in part from planters who wanted a regulated system of labor importation to reduce poaching of 'free' laborers by other estates. The colonial government itself also seemed anxious to create a more settled labor force, a concern that was tied up with a disdain for the Malayan-owned small holdings. In the 1923 *Annual Report on the Social and Economic Progress of the People of the Straits Settlements*, the colonial secretary complains of outbreaks of Mouldy Rot in Malacca which was spreading through the Malayan owned small holdings. He notes that the disease was absent on larger estates in part because "they have settled labor forces and do not employ coolies indiscriminately picked up, there being ordinarily therefore no contact with infected trees...."²⁴ In years during which the price of rubber fell, the smaller holdings could not afford prophylactic measures against disease, and so the Rubber Research Institute and the Departments of Co-operation and Agriculture developed a "Rural Lecture Caravan" which would tour villages in Malaya to give Malay-language lectures "on agricultural and co-operative subjects, illustrated or followed by the lantern slides and moving pictures in the evening." At least part of the goal seems to have been to discourage small holders from planting rubber altogether, as the section of the report on the Rural Lecture Caravan ends simply: "Good audiences were attracted and a number of enquiries for selected padi seed resulted."²⁵

24 Colonial Office Great Britain, "Annual Report on the Social and Economic Progress of the People of the Straits Settlements" (London: H.M. Stationary Office, 1923), 29.

25 Colonial Office Great Britain, "Annual Report on the Social and Economic Progress of the People of the Straits Settlements" (London: H.M. Stationary Office, 1931), 24.

Throughout the annual reports, a similar complaint recurs: that periods of high rubber prices had caused "land owners to plant up unsuitable land with rubber, so that in parts of Malacca and Province Wellesley low-lying land with a high water table, suitable for padi or certain annual crops, is often found to contain stunted and unhealthy rubber trees with an inadequate root system... finally it has caused public interest to be centred on rubber cultivation and has led to the neglect of all other crops giving reliable but smaller profits."²⁶ And then again in 1924: "as a general rule it can be stated that small holders have more frequently than large holders selected unsuitable (often swampy) land for rubber cultivation during the days of high prices."²⁷ The implication of these concerns is clear. In the eyes of the colonial secretary, not only were Asian workers vectors of disease who need to be corralled into their worksites, but even as administrators Malaysians were incompetent and needed to be educated at a great expense to the colonial apparatus. Malaysian planters should not share in the profits of export production, but should focus on producing domestic products like rice.

The annual reports of the colonial authorities in Malaya are shot through with a tension between the desire to affirm the formal equality of all British subjects and the desire to enrich the white planters at the expense of the non white populations - both indigenous and migrant. There was an urgent need for a system of labor hierarchy that would appease critics of bonded labor from India, but that would still meet the considerable need for a

26 Colonial Office Great Britain, "Annual Report on the Social and Economic Progress of the People of the Straits Settlements" (London: H.M. Stationary Office, 1922), 32.

27 Colonial Office Great Britain, "Annual Report on the Social and Economic Progress of the People of the Straits Settlements" (London: H.M. Stationary Office, 1924), 28.

compliant workforce. This tension is expressed quite aptly in a footnote to the 1917 annual report:

"Assisted immigrants" are of two classes: - (i) the independent labourer who gets a free ticket from the Emigration Agent in India upon proof that he is a bona fide labourer, and who is free to work where he pleases; (ii) the Kangany labourer, who is recruited in India by a licensed Kangany, and who goes to a particular place of employment, though he is free, upon arrival there, to give a month's notice of his intention to leave. There is no indentured Tamil labour in the Colony.²⁸

Laborers of both of these types had their transit costs covered by the Tamil Immigration Fund, and both were formally free to work for whomever they desired, but there were significant differences between them. It is odd that despite the significant costs of recruitment, workers produced by the kangany system were preferred to so-called independent laborers. This is partly due to the specifics of kangany recruitment: a former estate worker who wishes to become a recruiter first applies for a license and then "proceeds to his own village where he informs his friends and relations of the conditions of labour on his estate."²⁹ The kangany would then often travel back to Malaya with his recruits and serve as their overseer on the plantations. In his role as both overseer and recruiter, the kangany was able to exercise his authority as both job-giver and relative to ensure the compliance of the workforce.

Parmer makes an interesting claim about the effect that the kangany system had on the individual worker: he says that in the system of labor migration, "[e]xploitation was practiced - not by the planter but by the professional recruiter. The government, rather than

28 Colonial Office Great Britain, "Annual Report on the Social and Economic Progress of the People of the Straits Settlements" (London: H.M. Stationary Office, 1917), 28.

29 Colonial Office Great Britain, "Annual Report on the Social and Economic Progress of the People of the Straits Settlements" (London: H.M. Stationary Office, 1931), 25-27.

trying to abolish or reform the recruiter, had propped up the system by law."³⁰ Although I doubt that exploitation was "not [practiced] by the planter" - indeed there is much evidence to the contrary - this quote indicates that the colonial government was interested in, and had some success in, maintaining a system of exploitation and at the same time shifting that blame away from the planters and the colonial apparatus and onto an indigenous population - the kangany recruiters.

The following section will focus on the kangany system of recruitment. I will trace the development of the kangany into a hybrid role of recruiter and overseer, and its parallel with other overseer roles in Indian labor. Especially important is the fact that kanganies generally recruited from their own villages, and among their own kin. My discussion will demonstrate how the kangany system allowed the colonial state to resolve, for a time, the contradiction between bonded and free labor by exploiting existing family and community ties in the villages of the Madras Presidency.

Kangany Labor and the Families of Tamil Workers

The word kangany is of Tamil origin, indicating "“overseer” (kan means “eye” in Tamil); in the Tamil Bible, kangany is the term for a bishop, the overseer of the congregation."³¹ The kangany, however, forms part of a larger structure of labor recruitment and discipline throughout south and south-east Asia, called by different names in various places: *kangany*

³⁰ Parmer, *Colonial Labor Policy*, 25.

³¹ Amrith, *Crossing the Bay of Bengal*, 115.

among Tamil populations, especially in Malaya or Ceylon; *maistry* among Indian workers in Burma, and *sardar* in the region around Calcutta. Dipesh Chakrabarty discusses the sardar at length in *Rethinking Working Class History*, and although this role differed from the kangany in many ways, each being the product of a specific industry and local social context, they shared a common, and for our purposes crucial, feature: the exploitation of family and community bonds in service of labor recruitment and discipline.

For Chakrabarty, writing about the role of culture in the labor history of Bengali jute mills, the figure of the sardar represents a challenge to the dominant western historiography of capitalism. In his reading, Marx situated the working classes in the context of bourgeois social relations, most important of which were the category of citizenship, formal equality before the law, and the freedom of the contract. These categories of bourgeois equality are limited and "necessarily inimical to the construction of any socialist, communist, or communitarian ethic or order Yet Marxism shares in some of the premises of bourgeois egalitarianism (while being critical of it) and the task for classical Marxism was always one of transcending (in the Hegelian sense of the world) its shortcomings."³² In this reading, citizenship, equality, and contract-freedom are the constituent components of capitalism that serve as the grounds of contestation in the struggle to supercede capitalism. The sardar system however, as the prevailing structure of the Bengali working class, is based on a rather different social order: hierarchy rather than equality, and labor discipline based on family and community relations

³² Dipesh Chakrabarty, *Rethinking Working-Class History: Bengal, 1890-1940* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1989), xiii-xiv.

and their expectations rather than on the impersonal compulsion of the contract wage. For Chakrabarty, this radically different class structure requires a rethinking of the categories of capitalism and a more careful consideration of the role of 'culture' in the formation of the working classes.

Chakrabarty's intervention into the relationship between capitalism and bourgeois social relations is crucial, but his framing often falls short of his own insight. Rather than emphasizing the flexibility of capitalism and its ability to subsume diverse social structures in service of accumulation, he insists that the sardar system is 'precapitalist' or 'prebourgeois', at times indirectly reinforcing a heterodox, stagist conception of capitalist history. It is worth quoting Chakrabarty's discussion of the authority of the sardar over his workers at length:

The respect that the sardar commanded had roots in certain other aspects of the culture to which both the sardar and the worker belonged. It derived from a precapitalist culture with a strong emphasis on religion, community, kinship, language, and other similar loyalties. It seems significant, for instance, that all the words used by the workers (and others) to describe *sardari* extortions - payments summed up in the legalistic expression 'corruption' or 'abuses' - were words of precapitalist, pre-British origin: *dastoori*, *bakshish*, *batta*, *parbani*, *salami*, and so on.... Besides, the *sardar*'s mode of operation had certain crucial precapitalist elements. He usually recruited on the basis of the often overlapping networks of community, village, and kin.... Much of the *sardar*'s social control of the workforce lay in the relationships of community, kinship, religion, and so on, and in the ideas and norms associated with them.³³

Workers under a sardar were compelled to work not by the impersonal domination of the wage that we see in traditional marxist historiographies - the freedom to work or to starve - but by the personal domination of a family or community member who often employed naked

33 Chakrabarty, *Rethinking Working-Class History*, 112.

violence to compel his workers to labor. The division of personal and impersonal domination into 'pre-capitalist' and 'capitalist' forms of compulsion is common, and indeed the rapid expansion of the impersonal compulsion of the wage is a fundamentally capitalist development. But to assign all direct or personal forms of cultural and hierarchical domination to a category of 'pre-capitalism' is to underestimate the flexibility of capitalism in subsuming and transforming diverse social systems in the service of accumulation.

In the case of the kangany system on rubber plantations, the so-called 'pre-capitalist' pattern of domination through 'networks of community, village, and kin' were in fact constituent of global capitalist accumulation. They were not elements of an alternative path to capitalism specific to South Asia, but were crucial to the operation of capital as a global system, and in particular to the development of a global automotive industry that required large inputs of rubber. The 'strong emphasis on religion, community, kinship, language, and other similar loyalties' - and especially the bonds of family - transformed these relations into sites of exploitation and expropriation for western capitalists engaged in colonial industry.

Initially, the kangany system was relatively informal, and "most *kanganies* were simply the appointed spokesmen of gangs of laborers who traveled together from South India." They were common among the Tamil workers on coffee and tea plantations in Ceylon, and when planters traveled from Ceylon to Malaya in the late 19th century, they carried with them a preference for Tamil labor, organized under kanganies. As the distance from Madras to Malaya was far greater than the distance to Ceylon, the kanganies began to absorb more of

the role of recruiter in addition to overseer. They were particularly valuable in this role precisely because of the connections they maintained with their villages and communities back home in southern India. Upon being sent back home, they offered advances to family and community members who were able then to "free themselves from servitude, or to pay off debts incurred in times of dearth." These advances created new debts however, and although "relations of caste and kinship could moderate the kanganies' power ... such intimacy could also make the bonds of debt more pervasive."³⁴ Social and traditional bonds were therefore not maintained, exactly, but ruptured and reconfigured to serve the needs of plantation labor.

The exploitation of family connections between India and Malaya led to significant abuses by kanganies. Although the companies (and later the Tamil Immigration Fund) would pay the kangany's travel costs and expenses as well as a commission for each recruited worker, many kanganies resorted to exploitative practices to further enrich themselves. Once workers reached India, they were formally free, but this freedom only refers to the lack of a legal compulsion to work - the economic compulsion of debt was not only present, but was reinforced by the personal compulsion of hierarchical family and community ties. This is visible in the complaints of the behavior of kanganies during their recruiting trips to India. They exploited family and community connections in order to make commissions, drawing the ire of Indian officials:

A Madras government officer in 1925 listed the irregular recruiting practices as: obtaining recruits from professional recruiters or hotel-keepers; forging the signature of

³⁴ Amrith, *Crossing the Bay of Bengal*, 82-83.

village *munsifs* who from 1923 were required to see each intending emigrant; exploiting family quarrels to get some members of the family to emigrate; promising young men that they could find wives in Malaya; catching recruits at weekly "shandies;" matching strangers in order to circumvent the rule that minors and women be accompanied by a parent or relative; misrepresentation of work and wages; substitution of an unfit person for one already passed.³⁵

Despite these abuses, the kangany system was the preferred method of labor recruitment for both planters and the Malayan government. In fact, these abuses, insofar as they made the recruit dependent on the kangany, seem to have been implicitly condoned. After recruiting a batch of workers, the kangany would travel back to Malaya with them and serve as their overseer or foreman on the estate. Since the workers were formally free apart from their debt, planters were forced to "rel[y] on a combination of reasonable terms and the kangany's influence over the laborer to keep the laborer on the estate."³⁶

Amrith argues that this blurring of the lines between free and bonded labor was a central element in the system of labor migration across the Bay of Bengal. The manipulation of family and community ties allowed the governments to resolve the legal category of free labor with the planters need for compelled labor. The use of the kangany system and the creation of the legal fiction of the free Tamil laborer did not, however, stifle the outcry against the working conditions in Malaya. Both Indian Nationalists and British trade unionists decried the unfreedom of the labor in Malaya. In 1926 the Labour Research Department, a research organization affiliated with UK trade unions, published a report called "British

35 Parmer, *Colonial Labor Policy*, 58.

36 Parmer, *Colonial Labor Policy*, 22.

Imperialism in Malaya" which demanded solidarity between domestic industrial workers and migrant labor on the colonies: "British workers have to realize that the exploitation of cheap imported labor in Malaya is not a separate episode, but is part of the effort of capitalism to maintain itself by depressing the standards of all workers."³⁷ This depressed standard included dangerous working conditions, low wages, and compulsion to work. It is clear that British unionists considered the freedom of the laborer under the kangany system to be a mirage, noting that "[e]ven after the 'free' immigration scheme took the place of indentured labour, the deathrate remained appallingly high."³⁸ The assisted immigration scheme indeed served to undermine labor, and it contained the contradiction of unfree free labor in the colonies: "The Admiralty must co-operate with the planters in bringing over more wage workers; and some method other than an increase of wages must be found to induce them to come, because 'the forcing up of rates of pay will not help planters,' and a rising standard either of wages or leisure may stiffen the workers' demands." The end result: "the use of some form of compulsion, direct or indirect, such as has been applied in other parts of the British Empire."³⁹

Though reviled by the both Indian Nationalists and the British Left, the kangany system was strongly supported for decades by both the planters and the government of Malaya. However, this support began to erode towards the middle of the 20th century. This

37 "British Imperialism in Malaya," Colonial Series (London: Labour Research Department, 1926), 5.

38 "British Imperialism in Malaya," 37.

39 "British Imperialism in Malaya," 38.

erosion was effected by several forces: changing conditions in the global economy (especially the effect of the Great Depression on rubber demand), growing opposition in India to assisted emigration, and a desire to develop a domestic population of Tamils that could be exploited without the cost of importation. The issue of establishing a permanent Tamil laboring population was first raised in the 1920s, but was met with ambivalence from the planters and the government who were at that moment satisfied with the kangany system. In the thirties, however, the price of rubber dropped, and with it the wages paid to plantation workers. This resulted in a mass exodus of Tamil laborers who desired to return home, as well as Indian opposition to emigration due to the low wages. Although assisted emigration was restored in the early 1930s, quotas were asserted by the Indian government and from 1935 they demanded a partial restoration of wages. This was effected in 1937, and then rolled back the next year in 1938 due to production restrictions from the International Rubber Regulation Agreement.⁴⁰

Throughout the fracas between the Malayan and Indian governments, planters revisited the possibility of establishing a domestic population of Tamil workers. From 1922, Indian had established a sex ratio rule, which declared that "the number of male emigrants, unmarried or unaccompanied by wives, being assisted to emigrate must not exceed one in every five persons to any one country in any one year."⁴¹ Although Malaya was at times partially exempt from this rule, "[t]he Controller of Labor was of the opinion in 1935 that Malaya had already got a 'large permanent labour population' and that with an increasing number of Indian and

⁴⁰ Parmer, *Colonial Labor Policy*, 76.

⁴¹ Parmer, *Colonial Labor Policy*, 71.

Chinese female immigrants the tendency for laborers to remain in Malaya was increasing."⁴² Indeed, during the depression when the Indian Immigration Committee was offering to cover some of the costs of repatriation, many Tamils chose instead to stay in Malaya. Although planters were anxious about India cutting off the migrant labor supply, they evidently did not feel compelled to accept the Indian government's wage demands. In June of 1938, India halted all assisted emigration to Malaya. Negotiations for its resumption lasted until 1941 to no avail, at which point the Indian Immigration Committee and the Tamil Immigration Fund became effectively defunct.

The Aftermath: Coolie-hood and Repatriation

It is easy to read into the history of Tamil labor in Malaya a certain familiar teleology. Indentured labor gave way to the nominally free (though indebted) labor of the kangany system, which in the mid-century resolved into a fully capitalist system of overseeing mediated not by traditional forms of authority, but by the wage. I want to resist this reading by looking at the underside of this 'progression.' The primary effect of the slow development of formally free wage-labor among plantation workers occurred away from the plantations, in the creation of what to capital's standpoint appears to be a great mass of human detritus. For most workers, the category of 'coolie' persisted long after the brief period of plantation labor.

42 Parmer, *Colonial Labor Policy*, 75.

Coolie, like 'kangany', comes into English from Tamil: the word *kūli* being a payment for menial labor. According to Bremen and Daniel, "[b]eing a menial alone did not qualify a person to be called a 'coolie'; s/he had to be a menial who did not have any customary rights." The recipient of the *kūli* was totally severed from a traditional system of social connections: "[t]here was no one who accepted any responsibility for the survival of a menial who received *kūli*, and *kūli* never served as a token of such responsibility. *Kūli*, by its sheer paltriness, came to index the fact that the recipient belonged to 'the lowest level of the industrial labour market'."⁴³

This seems at first to simply be the process of proletarianization, but Bremen and Daniel note that the word 'coolie' carries also the connotation of the Gujarati word *Kuli*, a tribe whose "members were described as 'thieves, robbers, and plunderers, as degenerate and inferior,' in short, 'as a "villainous race"'.⁴⁴ In the coolie is embodied both the *kūli*, the wage which separates the laborer from communal patterns of subsistence, and the Kuli, a member of a community marked as racially inferior. Planters in search of cheap and malleable labor found the Tamil coolie to be "not so much a proletarian who stood ready to be transported to the rural and urban enclaves created by the new economy, but one who was available and vulnerable for recruitment by virtue of being cast adrift."⁴⁵ What was to become of the coolie when the work was up?

43 Jan Bremen and E. Valentine Daniel, "Conclusion: The Making of a Coolie," *The Journal of Peasant Studies* 19, no. 3–4 (1992), 269.

44 Bremen and Daniel, "Conclusion: The Making of a Coolie," 269.

45 Bremen and Daniel, "Conclusion: The Making of a Coolie," 270.

Most of the Tamil workers who migrated to Malaya did so only temporarily. Even in the years of indenture, they served fixed terms, returning home after their contract was up. After the abolition of indentured servitude, the majority of workers still returned home after working for a few years. The reasons for return were various, but perhaps the most significant driver was the global rubber market. With the onset of the great depression and the consequent collapse of rubber production in the early 1930s, previous immigration patterns were flipped on their head. The number of laborers whose passages to Malaya were paid for by the Tamil Immigration Fund from southern India fell from 42,771 in 1930 to only 111 the next year. Meanwhile in 1931 94,918 adults and children returned to India from Malaya, over half of whose passage was paid for by the Labour Department in Malaya.⁴⁶

Repatriation was a controversial topic in colonial India, and prominent Indian nationalists such as Gandhi, though first supporting the repatriation of emigrant workers, began to advocate for the rights of Indians to remain abroad in the communities that they had established. In a survey of the 'Repatriation Debate', Heena Mistry notes that opposition to repatriation often came from the repatriates themselves. Upon returning to their home villages, former immigrant workers sometimes found their position within the caste system questioned, as in the case of Bhawani Dayal Sannyasi who was born to an indentured father in South Africa and "saw himself as having an 'appearance, education, culture, and bearing' above the villagers, thus not meriting any treatment as an outcaste." As Sannyasi had been

46 Colonial Office Great Britain, "Annual Report on the Social and Economic Progress of the People of the Straits Settlements" (London: H.M. Stationary Office, 1931), 7.

born abroad, and as his mother had died before their return, his belonging to the kshatriya caste could not be verified. Rather than advocate on his behalf, his father told the "village *panchayat* that he would label his South-African born children as illegitimate in exchange for acceptance into the community."⁴⁷ Similarly Mistry notes that returnees from indentured labor in Fiji "were targeted by scammers and thieves upon their arrival or were ostracized in their ancestral villages."⁴⁸ Through the process of migrating abroad to work as a coolie, workers both lost their status in their old communities and, as discussed before, were considered by Indian planters to be unfit for work.

The situation for Tamil repatriates was much the same as in the rest of India. Amrith quotes the Indian Agent of Malaya's complaints of the effect of repatriation on migrants, saying that in the process "'no relief is thereby afforded' to Tamil workers, 'but that their suffering is merely transferred from Malaya to South India'."⁴⁹ Jan Bremen goes further and states that returned migrant workers "discovered that they were not 'peasants' but only coolies who had given up their chance of becoming peasants again."⁵⁰ Their ties to the land had been cut, and they were not able to reenter life in their villages on the old terms. He notes that returnees from the Malayan plantations were called by the epithet 'sucked oranges' - their vital forces used up. They were not at an intermediate step between peasant and free wage worker, but had been shunted into a permanent position of precarity.

47 Heena Mistry, "The Repatriation Debate After the Abolition of Indenture," *Journal of Indian Ocean World Studies* 5, no. 1 (2021), 127.

48 Mistry, "The Repatriation Debate After the Abolition of Indenture," 132-133.

49 Amrith, "Indians Overseas? Governing Tamil Migration to Malaya 1870-1941," 256.

50 Bremen and Daniel, "Conclusion: The Making of a Coolie," 278.

The persistence of coolie-hood beyond the contract term represents a break with the logic of capitalism, as traditionally understood. The arrival of Fordism in the world-economy did not bring proletarianization to South Asia, but but destitution. Family and community structures were exploited and used up in the production process, but no stable wage form was instituted in their stead. If we accept that the production of rubber was a capitalist phenomenon, and that it was a constituent part of the rise of Fordist industry then it becomes clear that the archetype of the Fordist worker is not the 5 dollar a day earning family man, but the footloose lumpen.

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